Palette play

Five Coolors palettes were supplied; the third and fifth are the same, so four are explored, plus two remixes. Each is mapped onto Margin's roles and drawn in the same editor fragment.

Method

Each palette colour takes the role that suits it. Text and control colours keep their hue and chroma; only their lightness moves until they pass WCAG (7:1 body text, 4.5:1 other text, 3:1 control outlines). Missing roles are derived and labelled as such.

What stays fixed

Margin's structure, type, shapes, and rules: page on desk, notes in the margin, glyphs for status, the accent only for things you can act on.

Plum and gold	Light	
Sea glass	Light	
Graphite	Dark	
Dusk	Dark	
Remix: Margin with plum and gold	Light	
Remix: Dusk night with gold	Dark	

Plum and gold

coolors.co/820263-d90368-eadeda-2e294e-ffd400. An illuminated manuscript: indigo ink, plum rubrics, gold leaf.

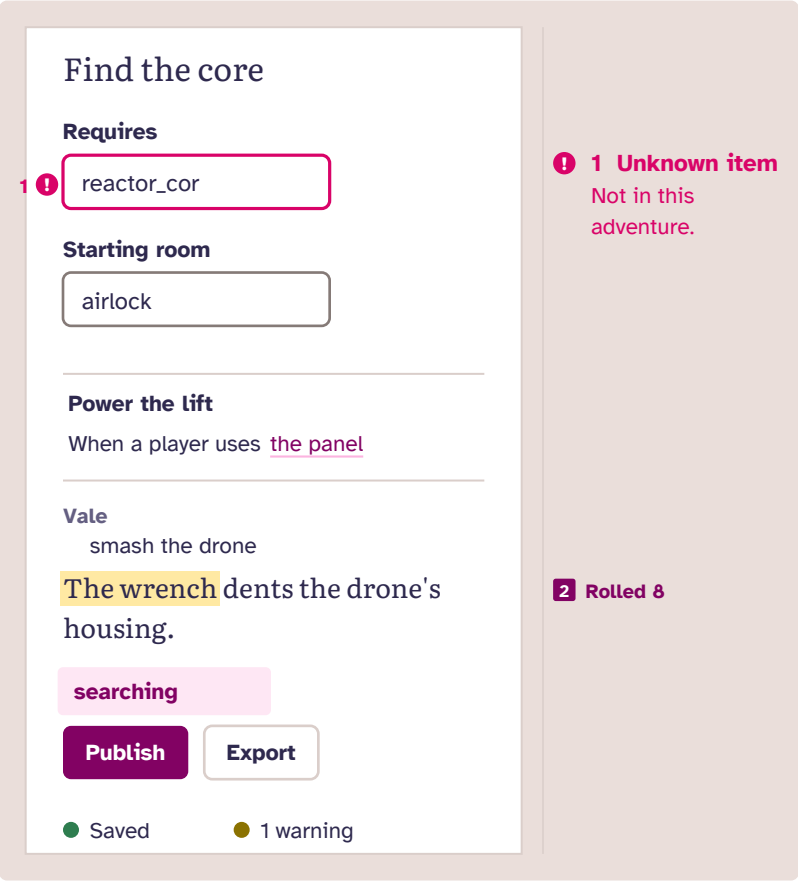
#820263
L 0.41 C 0.174 h 342
9.8:1 white, 2.1:1 black

#D90368
L 0.57 C 0.229 h 4
5.0:1 white, 4.2:1 black

#EADEDA
L 0.91 C 0.014 h 39
1.3:1 white, 16.0:1 black

#2E294E
L 0.31 C 0.065 h 288
13.6:1 white, 1.5:1 black

#FFD400
L 0.88 C 0.181 h 94
1.4:1 white, 14.7:1 black



Roles

- #820263 accent
- #D90368 danger
- #EADEDA desk
- #2E294E ink
- #FFD400 selection, warning source

Tuned tokens

a	ink #2E294E	13.6:1
a	muted #645F82	6.0:1
a	accent #820263	9.8:1
a	accent #820263	8.4:1
a	danger #D90368	5.0:1
a	warning #8B7201	4.7:1
a	success #2E7D4F	5.0:1
a	border #857A77	4.2:1
a	border #857A77	3.2:1
a	ink #2E294E	11.3:1

What works

- Indigo ink on white is warm and very legible (13.6:1).
- Plum reads as a deliberate editorial accent, not a default blue.
- Gold is excellent as a highlighter for selection and search, behind ink text.

Risks

- Plum (hue 342) and raspberry (hue 4) are 22 degrees apart; errors and actions look related. Glyphs carry the difference.
- Gold fails as text on white (1.4:1). Used as text it must darken to ochre, which loses its character.
- Pink-grey desk plus plum leans romantic; the manuscript reading depends on restraint elsewhere.

Sea glass

coolors.co/f0b67f-fe5f55-d6d1b1-c7efcf-eef5db. Pale, beachy pastels. Read as a status palette: coral for errors, peach for warnings, mint for success.

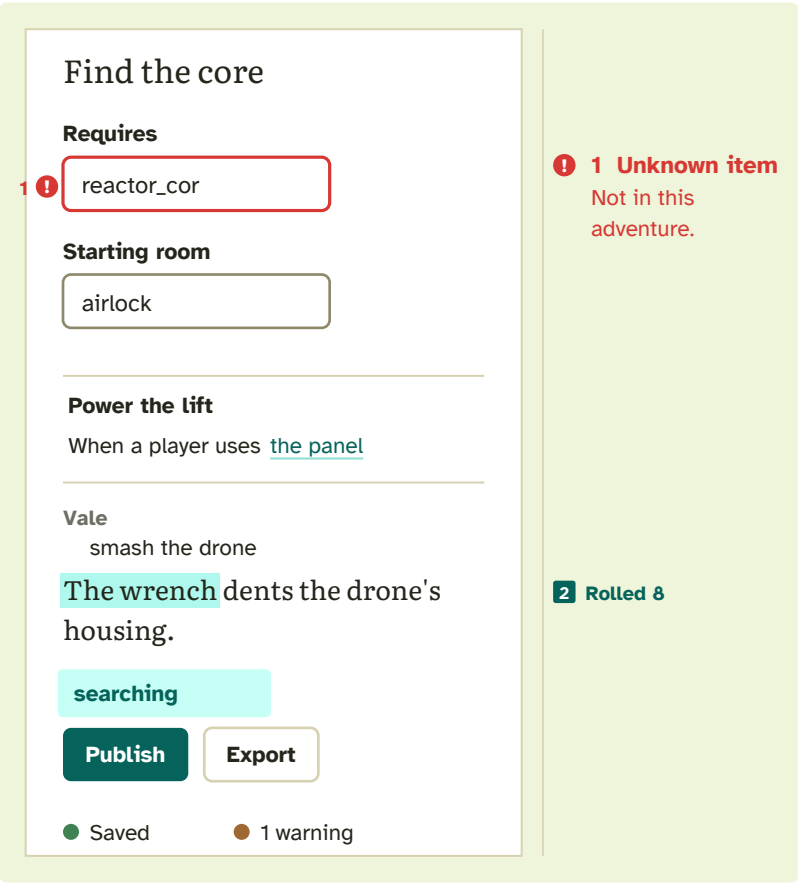
#F0B67F
L 0.82 C 0.098 h 64
1.8:1 white, 11.7:1 black

#FE5F55
L 0.69 C 0.196 h 27
3.0:1 white, 7.0:1 black

#D6D1B1
L 0.86 C 0.043 h 100
1.5:1 white, 13.6:1 black

#C7EFCF
L 0.92 C 0.060 h 151
1.3:1 white, 16.7:1 black

#EEF5DB
L 0.96 C 0.035 h 119
1.1:1 white, 18.7:1 black



Roles

- #F0B67F warning source
- #FE5F55 danger
- #D6D1B1 rule
- #C7EFCF success-soft
- #EEF5DB desk

Tuned tokens

a	ink #23261B	15.4:1
a	muted #6D6F65	5.1:1
a	accent #05635B	7.1:1
a	accent #05635B	6.5:1
a	danger #D73834	4.7:1
a	warning #9E6832	4.7:1
a	success #408253	4.6:1
a	border #8E896B	3.5:1
a	border #8E896B	3.2:1
a	ink #23261B	12.8:1

What works

- Coral, peach, and mint map naturally onto error, warning, and success.
- The pale green desk is calmer than grey and keeps the white page bright.

Risks

- No dark colour at all: ink and accent had to be invented (olive-black ink, a deep teal accent).
- Coral needs darkening from 3.0:1 to pass as text, and peach from 1.8:1; both become brown-red and brown.
- Cream ground with a coral accent is close to the editorial look the research flagged as AI-generated.
- Pastel surfaces at 1.1 to 1.5:1 give almost no structure; borders do all the work.

Graphite

coolors.co/323031-3d3b3c-7f7979-c1bdb3-5f5b6b (listed twice). Warm pencil greys with a dusky violet. Strongest as a night mode.

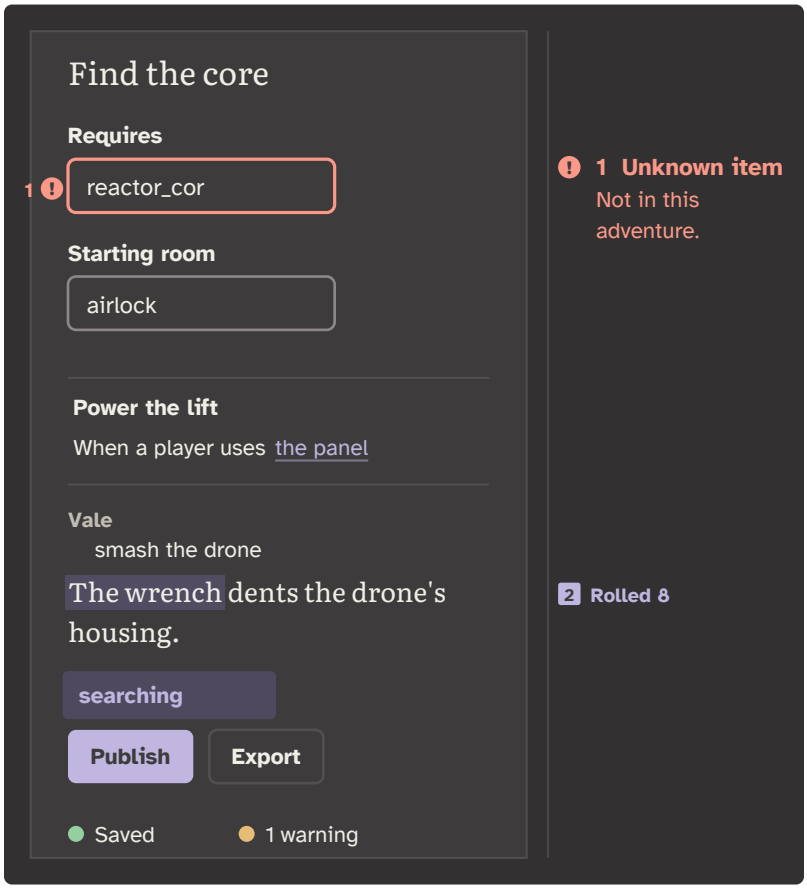
#323031
L 0.31 C 0.003 h 345
13.1:1 white, 1.6:1 black

#3D3B3C
L 0.35 C 0.003 h 345
11.1:1 white, 1.9:1 black

#7F7979
L 0.58 C 0.007 h 17
4.3:1 white, 4.9:1 black

#C1BDB3
L 0.80 C 0.015 h 89
1.9:1 white, 11.2:1 black

#5F5B6B
L 0.48 C 0.026 h 297
6.6:1 white, 3.2:1 black



Roles

- #323031 desk
- #3D3B3C page
- #7F7979 border
- #C1BDB3 muted
- #5F5B6B accent source

Tuned tokens

a ink #F1EEE8	9.6:1
a muted #C1BDB3	5.9:1
a accent #C1B6E0	5.8:1
a accent #C1B6E0	4.5:1
a danger #FB9989	5.3:1
a warning #E6BD77	6.3:1
a success #94CF9F	6.2:1
a border #8E8787	3.2:1
a border #8E8787	3.7:1
a ink #F1EEE8	7.1:1

What works

- Warm, low-chroma greys feel like pencil on card; easier on the eyes than blue-black dark modes.
- Page and desk are close (1.2:1) but distinct, matching Margin's page-on-desk structure.
- Sand (#C1BDB3) is a ready-made secondary text colour at 5.9:1.

Risks

- The violet (#5F5B6B) has almost no chroma; as an accent it has to be lifted to lavender, or links look like text.
- Status colours are absent and must come from Margin's ramps, desaturated to sit in the greys.
- The supplied page and desk are only 1.1 apart in lightness; on poor screens they merge.

Dusk

coolors.co/84828f-6a687a-536271-3e4c5e-2c3d55. Slate blues from dusk to night: a cool night mode, close to Margin's own ink hue.

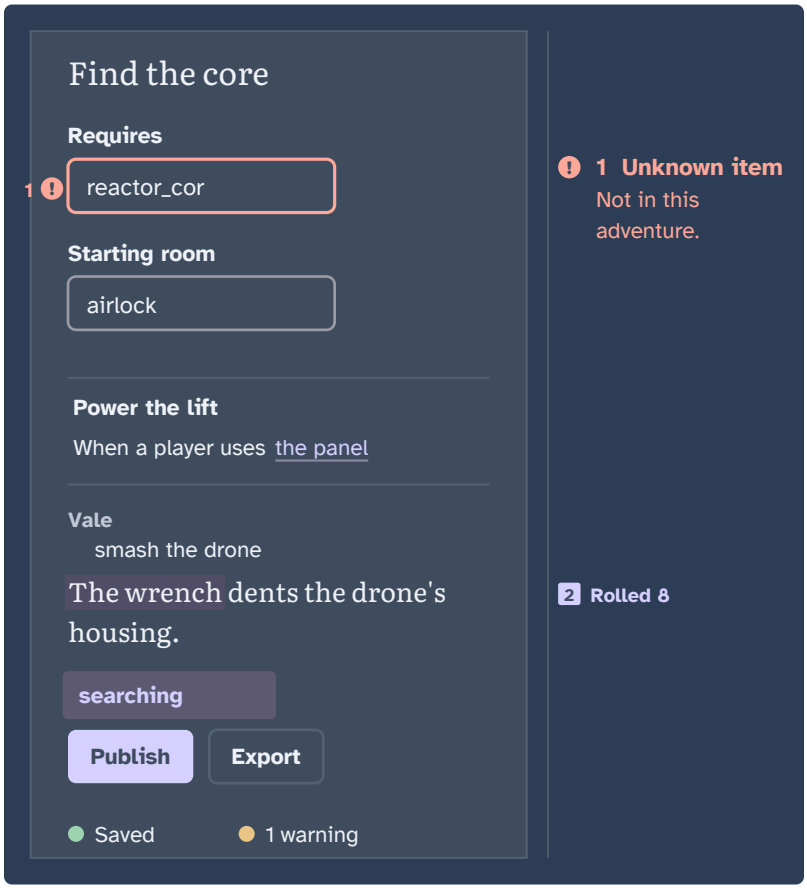
#84828F
L 0.61 C 0.020 h 293
3.8:1 white, 5.6:1 black

#6A687A
L 0.53 C 0.028 h 290
5.4:1 white, 3.9:1 black

#536271
L 0.49 C 0.030 h 248
6.3:1 white, 3.4:1 black

#3E4C5E
L 0.41 C 0.035 h 255
8.7:1 white, 2.4:1 black

#2C3D55
L 0.36 C 0.047 h 257
11.0:1 white, 1.9:1 black



Roles

- #2C3D55 desk
- #3E4C5E page
- #536271 rule
- #84828F border, muted source
- #6A687A accent source

Tuned tokens

a	ink #EEF1F6	7.7:1
a	muted #C2C7D5	5.2:1
a	accent #D5D0FF	6.0:1
a	accent #D5D0FF	4.6:1
a	danger #FFA798	4.7:1
a	warning #E8C586	5.3:1
a	success #9BD4AE	5.2:1
a	border #9C9AA7	3.2:1
a	border #9C9AA7	4.0:1
a	ink #EEF1F6	7.1:1

What works

- Hue 255 to 293 sits beside Margin's 266, so it reads as Margin at night rather than a new brand.
- Lighter than most dark modes: the page is L 0.41, a dusk rather than a void.

Risks

- Every colour is mid-dark and low chroma; there is no light colour for text, so ink and muted are derived.
- The page is light for a dark mode; long reading may feel grey rather than restful.
- The supplied lavender (#6A687A) fails as text on the page (1.6:1) and must be lifted far.

Remix: Margin with plum and gold

Margin neutrals; plum accent and gold highlighter from palette 1. Keep Margin's slate page and desk; take only the plum accent and the gold highlighter.

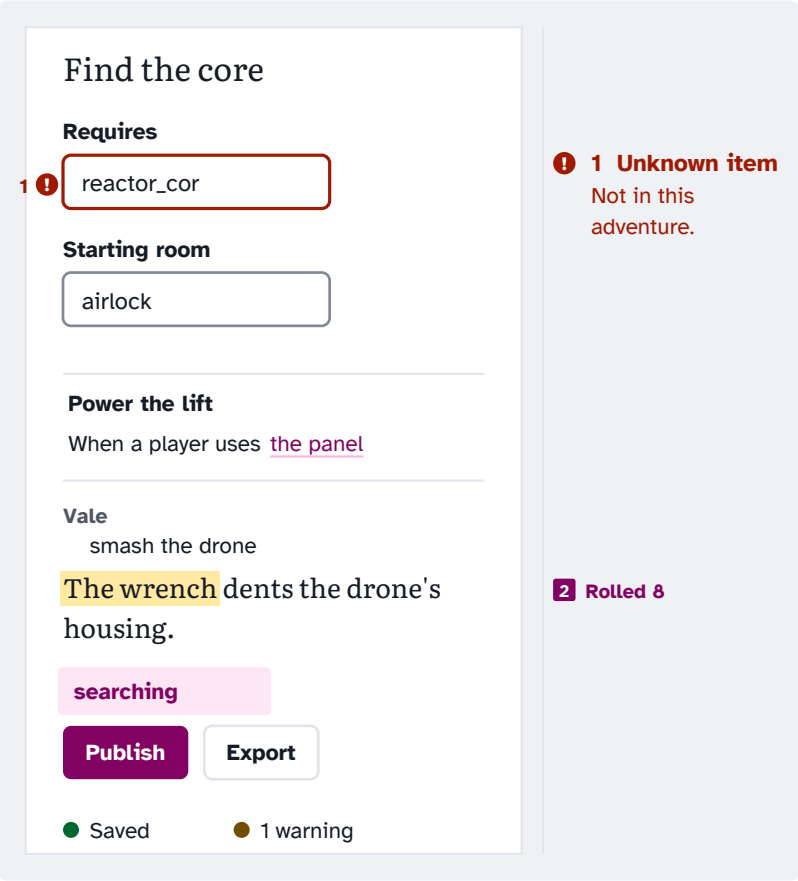
#FFFFFF
L 1.00 C 0.000 h 90
1.0:1 white, 21.0:1 black

#EFF1F4
L 0.96 C 0.005 h 258
1.1:1 white, 18.6:1 black

#161B25
L 0.22 C 0.021 h 264
17.2:1 white, 1.2:1 black

#820263
L 0.41 C 0.174 h 342
9.8:1 white, 2.1:1 black

#FFD400
L 0.88 C 0.181 h 94
1.4:1 white, 14.7:1 black



Roles

- #FFFFFF page
- #EFF1F4 desk
- #161B25 ink
- #820263 accent
- #FFD400 selection

Tuned tokens

a	ink #161B25	17.2:1
a	muted #505663	7.4:1
a	accent #820263	9.8:1
a	accent #820263	8.4:1
a	danger #9F1A02	8.0:1
a	warning #724E00	7.5:1
a	success #026833	6.9:1
a	border #818895	3.6:1
a	border #818895	3.2:1
a	ink #161B25	14.3:1

What works

- Cool greys plus a warm plum accent: distinctive without colouring the whole interface.
- Gold selection is memorable and functional, echoing a highlighter on a manuscript.
- Margin's correction red stays clearly separate from plum (hue 32 against 342).

Risks

- Plum on a cool grey desk is a stronger contrast of temperature; keep it to actions only.

Remix: Dusk night with gold

Dusk neutrals from palette 4; gold highlighter from palette 1. Margin's night mode drawn from Dusk, with gold as the accent instead of lavender.

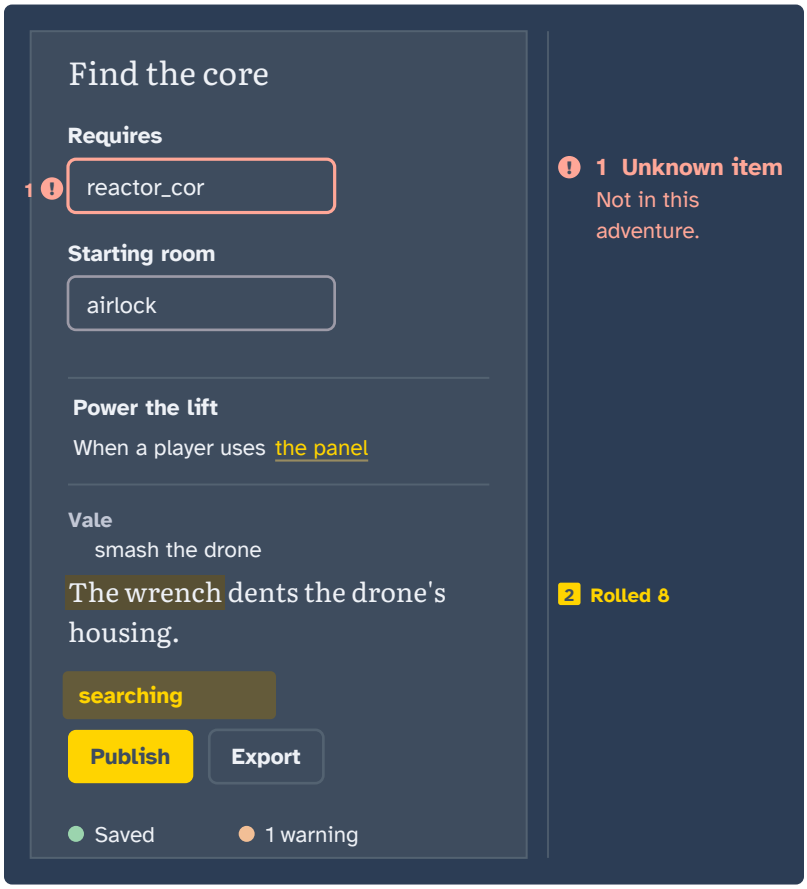
#2C3D55
L 0.36 C 0.047 h 257
11.0:1 white, 1.9:1 black

#3E4C5E
L 0.41 C 0.035 h 255
8.7:1 white, 2.4:1 black

#536271
L 0.49 C 0.030 h 248
6.3:1 white, 3.4:1 black

#84828F
L 0.61 C 0.020 h 293
3.8:1 white, 5.6:1 black

#FFD400
L 0.88 C 0.181 h 94
1.4:1 white, 14.7:1 black



Roles

- #2C3D55 desk
- #3E4C5E page
- #536271 rule
- #84828F border
- #FFD400 accent

Tuned tokens

a	ink #EEF1F6	7.7:1
a	muted #C2C7D5	5.2:1
a	accent #FFD400	6.1:1
a	accent #FFD400	4.7:1
a	danger #FFA798	4.7:1
a	warning #F2BF96	5.3:1
a	success #9BD4AE	5.2:1
a	border #9C9AA7	3.2:1
a	border #9C9AA7	4.0:1
a	ink #EEF1F6	7.1:1

What works

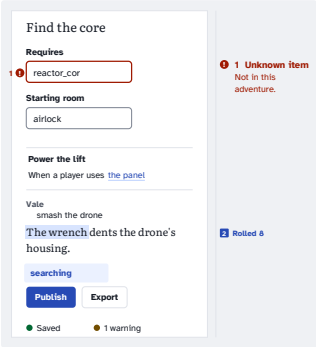
- Gold on slate is the most vivid accent of the dark options (6.1:1) and feels like lamplight.
- Complements the light remix: plum by day, gold by night, same structure.

Risks

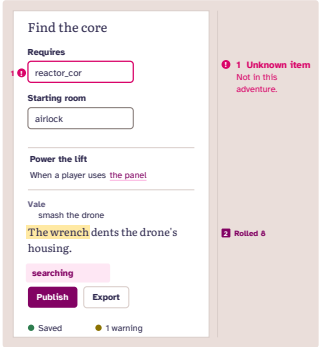
- Gold and the warning ochre are close in hue; warning shifts toward orange here, and glyphs separate them.
- A different accent per mode breaks the rule that blue means act; the rule becomes 'the accent means act'.

Side by side

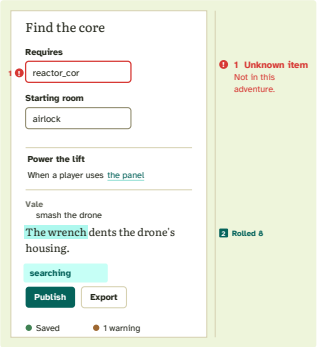
The same fragment in every exploration, with Margin's current palette for reference.



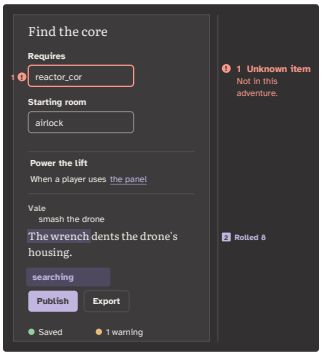
Margin, current



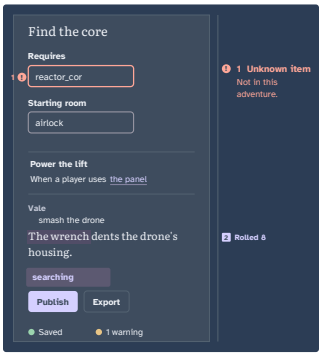
Plum and gold



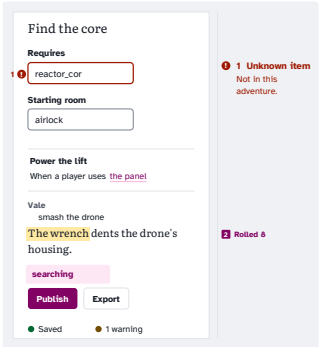
Sea glass



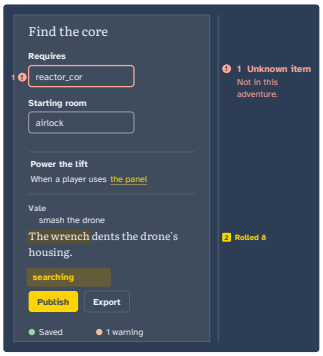
Graphite



Dusk



Margin with plum and gold



Dusk night with gold

Recommendation

What to take from the palettes, in order of fit with Margin.

1. Light: Margin with plum and gold

Keep slate page, desk, and ink. Replace the blue accent with plum #820263 and use gold #FFE9A3 (from #FFD400) for selection and search. Plum is distinctive; red stays far from it in hue.

2. Dark: Dusk with gold, or Graphite

Dusk keeps Margin's cool hue at night; Graphite is warmer and softer. Either way use a light accent with real chroma: gold on Dusk, lavender on Graphite.

3. Sea glass as status tints only

Coral, peach, and mint make pleasant soft backgrounds behind notes. As a whole palette it lacks ink and drifts toward the cream-and-coral cliché.

Avoid

Raspberry beside plum for errors; gold or coral as text; a page that is not near-white in light mode.

Open question

Should the accent differ between light and dark (plum by day, gold by night), or stay one hue in both? One hue is simpler to explain; two hues give each mode its own light.